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Newsom perceived as open to more gun control

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SACRAMENTO - California has some of the strictest gun laws in the country, but even as they passed measures in the aftermath of mass shootings, legislators occasionally found themselves frustrated by former Gov. Jerry Brown and his veto pen.

Now they sense fresh opportunity under Gov. Gavin Newsom, a supporter of tightening gun laws who sponsored a successful ballot initiative in 2016 to institute background checks for ammunition sales.

At a Capitol news conference Monday with former Arizona Rep. Gabby Giffords, lawmakers rattled off proposals vetoed by Brown that they intend to revive this legislative session, including a limit of one rifle or shotgun purchase per month and more regulation of parts that can be turned into homemade weapons.

"Stopping gun violence takes courage - the courage to do what's right," said Giffords, who was gravely wounded in a 2011 assassination attempt. "We must never stop fighting."

California legislators said they hope to make the state a model for the rest of the nation.

Other measures that lawmakers have already introduced this year include a requirement for gun owners to lock up their weapons when they are not home, a 10-year prohibition of firearm possession for anyone convicted of two drug or alcohol crimes in a three-year period, and a tax on gun sales to fund violence prevention programs.

Assemblyman Phil Ting, D-San Francisco, has also brought back his 2018 bill to allow more people to seek a gun violence restraining order against someone they believe poses a danger to themselves or others. Brown vetoed the measure, which would have permitted co-workers and school personnel to petition a court to temporarily remove firearms from a person. Current law allows only family members, roommates and law enforcement to seek such orders.

"Washington, D.C., has failed us," said Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Los Angeles, who is carrying legislation to mandate training for police about gun violence restraining orders, a tool that officers have been slow to adopt. "It's clear to us that no matter how much tragedy we experience, President Trump and his allies in Congress are unwilling to take any action to stop mass shootings or gun violence. Thoughts and prayers from Washington won't keep our kids safe."

Shortly after his election in November, Newsom said he wanted to "raise the bar" on gun control in California, prompting speculation that he would be open to signing bills that Brown vetoed.

While Newsom is unlikely to take a position on any of the bills as they are making their way through the legislative process, spokesman Jesse Melgar said in an email, "he is a big believer in strong gun safety laws."

That has not escaped the notice of gun rights proponents, who believe Newsom poses a far greater threat to their cause than Brown did.

Craig DeLuz, director of legislative and public affairs for the Firearms Policy Coalition, said that while Brown governed as a liberal on guns, he was open to gun rights groups' arguments that some bills were impractical or unconstitutional.

For Newsom, however, "this is a PR issue. It's not about making people safer or protecting the rights of Californians," DeLuz said. "He'll likely sign anything that was put before him."

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